Karachi and the Persian Gulf.[19] The most passionate champion of the Swadeshi company, Bharati would provide a sustained commentary on its progress—and its tragic decline—in the following years.

Not all were as gung-ho as Bharati. Sceptics were not wanting. In response to VOC's appeal that *Swadesamitran* had carried with its own title, 'Swadeshism in Tuticorin: A Laudable Effort', one Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar joined issue under the title: 'A Warning to Tuticorin's Patriot.'[20]

The inauspicious title apart, Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar prefaced his rejoinder by saying that readers should not mistake it for a rebuttal of VOC's claims —which, of course, it was. Firstly, Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar called attention to an earlier effort at running a steamer line between Madras and Rangoon undertaken by some Nattukkottai Chettiar and Muslim merchants, and pointed out how the BI Agents, Binnys, wrecked it by cutting rates. Despite being a substantial presence in Burma, Penang and Singapore, he expressed displeasure at Nattukkottai Chettiars for not sufficiently imbibing the Swadeshi spirit. In this context, he pointed out that the number of Nattukkottai Chettiar merchants in Colombo was much smaller.

Moreover, the Tuticorin–Colombo route was dominated by the passage of plantation labour. Though plantation labourers numbered some 10 lakh (his estimate) they were under the thumb of less than a thousand planters who were well organized under a planters' association. As Europeans, the planters would naturally side with BI. Further, given its deep pockets, BI could easily afford to even provide free passage to labourers for several years. What would be the fate of Indian investors then, Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar wondered. Given this situation, he called upon VOC to sit at the table with the Swadeshi merchants, work out their staying power and then publicize the resultant figures. He also called for more intense campaigning for the Swadeshi cause by recruiting volunteers.

For their part, the traders, emulating Christian evangelicals in their zeal, should take a solemn vow to use only the Swadeshi steamer service for at least five years. Pointing to the earlier experience of cotton mills in Kovilpatti, sugar mills in Thachanallur and oil mills at Pettai (all within the Tirunelveli district), he said, despite the best of intentions Swadeshi